

Skip to my, skip to my, skip to my Lou. Skip to my, skip to my, skip to my Lou. Skip to my, skip to my, skip to my Lou. Skip to my Lou, my dar - lin'.

◁ Recognize the tune?

Did you guess the tune from either its distinctive rhythm, or its characteristic melody? It is "Skip to My Lou." Here it is in its entirety.

Wordless tunes

Often tunes are so memorable that even if they have words, the text is less distinctive than the melody itself. If a melody's pitch and rhythm are unforgettable, even humming it without any words at all is rewarding. A good tune is catchy regardless of its words, as in the example shown below.

▽ "Deck the Halls"

What is the most unique thing about this tune—the rhythm or the pitches? It's probably not the words!

Deck the halls with boughs of hol - ly! Fa la la la la fa la la la!

Do it yourself

Try taking the rhythm of a tune you already know and write a new set of pitches to go along with it. For example, take the rhythmic notation for "Skip to My Lou" and write a new melody to that rhythm. Next, use just the pitches to "Skip to My Lou" and create a new rhythm.

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▽ Create a new rhythm

Use the natural meter of the lyrics and vary it to create a new rhythmic pattern. Try for just the right amount of repetition and contrast.

△ New melody

Try out your new melody to see if it's "singable." Are the phrases pleasing, and does the contour of the notes fit within your voice?

Original melody

New rhythm

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